

multiple projects of the same code base or different ones.

Word processing tools

The editor comes with a rich set of word processing capabilities, like filtering the file contents, beautifying the code (specific to the language), removing empty lines, converting files from dos2unix, removing duplicate lines, etc. Many command line utilities to process files can be added.

One interesting feature in word processing is the *Synchronise Text Block* feature. When multiple files are open, one can ensure a block of code is the same across the files. One of the scenarios could be that the copyright text needs to be the same across files. Another scenario could be when the footer for all Web pages needs to be exactly the same across different pages. To ensure that, you can use the *Synchronise Text Block* feature. The editor allows you to mark the beginning and the end of the section you need to synchronise. Note that these sections will be overwritten in all destination files.

Spell check

Bluefish comes with the spell check feature, which is useful when developing Web pages that have a lot of content. The user has the option of selecting the language and the locale at the time of editing, based on language sets chosen at the time of installation. The editor also gives the option to 'Add to dictionary' and 'Ignore' a spelling.

Code block folding

For easy code navigation, Bluefish offers a way to collapse and expand blocks of code. The blocks are automatically identified based on the programming language. To identify more types of blocks, you can modify the default settings in 'Preferences'. For example, in PHP, Bluefish can identify the comments block, PHP code snippets, HTML sections and JavaScript functions as separate sections.

Advanced features of Bluefish

File Browser - Open Advanced

When you need to browse a large project with multiple files, it would be painful to open one file at a time. Bluefish gives an option to open multiple files from a directory. Right click on a directory (left side panel) and select 'Open Advanced ...' Files can be opened based on type (.css, .java, .html), a string or pattern within the file and also recursively traverse multiple sub-directories.

Bookmarking

When browsing code across multiple files or a single large file, bookmarks come handy. They let you pin a few locations of code that you would like to switch to frequently. The bookmarks are persistent across sessions of Bluefish.

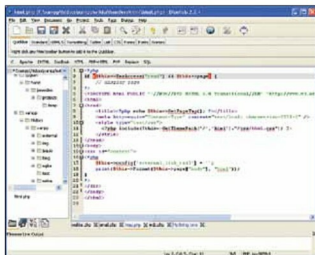


Figure 1: Screen layout

Additionally, you can create bookmarks based on a pattern. This would be useful if you want to review functions that all start with a common string. In the 'Advanced Find and Replace' dialogue box, there is the option to bookmark all lines that match a string. The capability to match a regular expression makes it more powerful.

Find and Replace

All editors support the *Find* and *Replace* functions.

Additionally, Bluefish allows restricting or expanding the scope of the search to different scenarios. If a chunk of text is selected and then the *Find* and *Replace* dialogue opened, the scope of the search is restricted to the selection.

The search can be restricted from the current point to the end of the document. To expand the scope of the search, you can search the entire document, all open documents in the editor or a complete directory. Searching the complete directory and also being able to select file-types (.h or .css) is a powerful feature. Bluefish also allows you to define the depth of directory navigation for a search.

Bluefish is one of the few editors that supports regular expressions in search and replace. This is very helpful with browser Web pages with mark-up. You can search for all the places that a particular HTML tag is used and replace the deprecated tags with a new one. For example, different programmers use different ways to specify the background-colour of HTML elements. They could use key words like 'red' or rgb(255,0,0) or hex code. To search all the places that hex code was used, the search string could be: `background-color: #[0-9A-F]+;`

The power of regular expressions is exploited when you want to convert a huge HTML table to insert records within the MySQL database using PHP code!

Syntax highlighting

Bluefish supports multiple programming, scripting and mark-up languages, which means it can identify the syntax (grammar) of each language and also give visual